Decoding ISO 9001 2026 Clause 8 Operation

Requirements design external provision production and release



Maintain a defensible chain from the customer promise to the evidence authorising delivery.

Expanded practitioner edition for IMS managers, engineers and leadership teams

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RPG Excellence | Management Systems and Business Assurance

Using this publication

Maintain a defensible chain from the customer promise to the evidence authorising delivery.

This expanded practitioner edition explains every numbered subclause within Clause 8 of the supplied ISO 9001:2026 text. It develops the earlier RPG collected technical insights into a standalone working guide with operational examples, role applications, two reusable worksheets and two printable poster annexes.

Requirements and recommendations

The required outcomes are original paraphrases of the supplied standard. Its informative Annex A clarifies meaning without adding requirements. Practical methods, scenarios, sample sizes, worksheet fields, review periods and poster prompts in this book are RPG recommendations, unless a requirement is expressly identified. Use a licensed copy for the complete normative text. [1]

How to read it

Begin with the working language and coverage route. Read the relevant clause interpretation, then follow one real process with its owner. Use the cases to challenge your reasoning and the worksheets to record a decision. The annexes can support team discussion; they are not exhaustive audit checklists.

Technical basis

Supporting referrals were checked against official public publication records on 8 November 2026. Many APG papers and ISO/TS 9002:2016 address the earlier edition. Use them only where consistent with the 2026 requirement. ISO 9000 supplies the normative vocabulary referral. Other supporting publications do not automatically expand ISO 9001 requirements.

All organisations, events and figures in the cases are fictional teaching examples. They are not customer results, statistical benchmarks or promised savings. Photographs are illustrative. This guide does not establish certification or replace applicable technical, contractual or legal assessment.

Working language and practical translation

These are plain English working explanations, not formal quotations or replacements for ISO 9000 definitions. The application column shows the decision each term should help a reader make.

Term	Working explanation	Practical translation
Requirement review	A decision about the promise and capability before commitment.	Resolve gaps before representing the output as agreed.
Design review	Evaluation of whether the design can meet its requirements.	Identify the questions and the action on any problem.
Verification	Checking design output against the specified input requirements.	Keep the link from requirement to result.
Validation	Checking suitability for the specified application or intended use.	Use conditions representative of that purpose.
Concession	An authorised acceptance decision for a specified departure.	Do not report it as fulfilment of the original requirement.
Release	Authorised progression or supply supported by the planned acceptance evidence.	Connect the decision to the actual output and criterion.

Read the verbs carefully

A requirement calls for fulfilment. Guidance suggests a possible approach. Thinking about an issue differs from incorporating it into a decision. Suitability depends on the organisation’s context, while applicability concerns whether a requirement is relevant to the situation. The supplied Annex A.2 and the vocabulary referrals help resolve these distinctions. [1]

Do not turn a preferred template, score or software workflow into a requirement simply because it is familiar. Equally, do not use flexible wording to avoid an outcome the standard actually requires.

Clause coverage and reading route

The references below cover every numbered subclause within this book’s main clause. Where related subclauses share a page, their required outcomes are distinguished in the text. Parent headings organise the requirements and are included in this coverage.

Covered references	Interpretation section
8.1	8.1 Plan and control the actual delivery process
8.2, 8.2.1, 8.2.2	8.2.1 and 8.2.2 Communication and defined requirements
8.2.3, 8.2.3.1, 8.2.3.2, 8.2.4	8.2.3 and 8.2.4 Review before commitment and control changes
8.3, 8.3.1, 8.3.2	8.3.1 and 8.3.2 Establish and plan design control
8.3.3, 8.3.4	8.3.3 and 8.3.4 Inputs review verification and validation
8.3.5, 8.3.6	8.3.5 and 8.3.6 Outputs and design changes
8.4, 8.4.1, 8.4.2	8.4.1 and 8.4.2 Provider selection and proportionate controls
8.4.3	8.4.3 Tell the provider what correct provision requires
8.5, 8.5.1	8.5.1 Controlled production and service conditions
8.5.2, 8.5.3	8.5.2 and 8.5.3 Identity status and entrusted property
8.5.4, 8.5.5, 8.5.6	8.5.4 to 8.5.6 Preserve conformity and control later changes
8.6	8.6 Release supported by the actual acceptance evidence
8.7, 8.7.1, 8.7.2	8.7 Control the nonconforming output and its decision history

The question to carry through the book

What prevents an excellent inspection from accepting work against the wrong requirement?

Read across the system

Clause interpretation supports a working process. It does not require the organisation’s manuals, software modules or department structure to mirror the numbering of the standard. The links to other clauses in this book help preserve that systems perspective. [1, A.1, A.2]

8.1 Plan and control the actual delivery process

Required outcome

Plan, implement and control the processes that fulfil product and service requirements and the actions established through Clause 6. Determine requirements, acceptance criteria, process criteria and resources, and operate the controls accordingly. Provide sufficient documented information for confidence in planned operation and evidence of output conformity. Control planned changes, review unintended changes and mitigate adverse consequences. Keep relevant external provision controlled. [1]

Practical translation

Operational planning connects the promise with the conditions needed to fulfil it. It should establish what correct work looks like, what will demonstrate that condition and what happens if the planned route cannot be followed. It includes purchased and outsourced activities that affect the output.

Application in the work

For an engineering order, connect the agreed drawing, manufacturing route, provider requirements, inspection stages and release evidence. For a professional service, connect the agreed scope, required inputs, competent delivery and acceptance conditions. A quality plan can organise these links for a particular contract.

Evidence and judgement

Trace one accepted order through the planned route and one exception. Check whether resources were available, whether criteria were consistent and whether the retained evidence supports the result. A plan that cannot be applied to the actual job needs reconsideration.

Avoid this mistake

A completed scheduling board does not establish all the necessary controls. ISO 9001 does not require a document called a quality plan for every job, although the organisation or customer may require one.

Guidance referral

A.8.1 explains operational interfaces. ISO 10005:2018 is an optional referral for a quality plan; ISO 10007:2017 supports configuration management. [4,5]

8.2.1 and 8.2.2 Communication and defined requirements

Required outcome

Under 8.2.1, customer communication covers product and service information, enquiries and commitments including changes, feedback and complaints, customer property, and relevant contingency information, including disruptions. Under 8.2.2, define the requirements for the proposed output, including applicable statutory and regulatory requirements and those the organisation determines necessary. Be capable of meeting the claims made for it. [1]

Practical translation

A public product description and a private technical agreement can both influence the promise. Requirements are not limited to what appears on the purchase order. The organisation needs an accurate account of the output it proposes to provide and the conditions under which its claims hold.

Application in the work

A service advertises a report within two days. Clarify the inputs, review conditions and exclusions needed to make that statement accurate. A customer then requests a different method or format. Ensure that communication changes the agreed requirement and operating plan rather than existing only in an email thread.

Evidence and judgement

Compare the website claim, quotation, order, technical specification and delivery information for one service. Review how feedback and a disruption are communicated to the affected customer. Assign responsibility for consequential claims and changes.

Avoid this mistake

Marketing communication is not outside the quality system simply because it is public. Conversely, the clause does not prescribe one communication channel or require a formal meeting for every order.

Guidance referral

A.8.2 explains customer communication. ISO 10002:2018 is a supporting referral for complaints handling. [6]

8.2.3 and 8.2.4 Review before commitment and control changes

Required outcome

Under 8.2.3.1, establish capability before committing to supply. Review the customer's requirements, delivery and relevant later obligations, requirements necessary for known intended use, organisational requirements, applicable legal requirements and differences from earlier commitments. Resolve differences and confirm customer requirements when no documented statement is supplied. Under 8.2.3.2, keep applicable evidence of the review and new or changed requirements. Under 8.2.4, update relevant information and communicate changed requirements to relevant parties. [1]

Practical translation

Review is the point at which the business decides whether its proposed commitment is supportable. A signed order is not evidence that technical, capacity or requirement conflicts were resolved. A changed drawing needs to reach the work already planned as well as future quotations.

Application in the work

A customer tightens a tolerance after the order is accepted. Check the capability, work already completed, provider specifications, measuring method and release criteria. Obtain the required agreement before representing the old arrangement as meeting the new requirement. Track the effect of the change across the actual job.

Evidence and judgement

Compare the original and changed requirements with the review decision, authorisation and information reaching operations. For standard online products, the review can be implemented through an adequate controlled catalogue and acceptance process rather than a separate manual review of every transaction.

Avoid this mistake

Silence is not a reliable way to resolve conflicting requirements. A review conducted after an unsupported commitment cannot retrospectively demonstrate that the earlier capability judgement was made.

Guidance referral

A.8.2 provides clarification. An organisation may use a change log or acceptance gate; those are implementation choices rather than mandated document titles.

8.3.1 and 8.3.2 Establish and plan design control

Required outcome

Under 8.3.1, establish, operate and maintain a design and development process suitable for subsequent provision. Under 8.3.2, plan stages and controls in light of complexity and duration, review, verification and validation needs, responsibilities, resources, interfaces, relevant customer or party involvement, later delivery needs, expected control levels and the evidence needed to show the design requirements have been met. [1]

Practical translation

Design converts requirements into defined characteristics of a product or service. It can apply to a service methodology, not only to physical drawings. Whether the requirement applies depends on responsibility and activity, not on whether a department is named Design.

Application in the work

A company develops a new inspection service from a customer problem. Plan who defines its intended use, who reviews the method, what verification establishes technical consistency and what validation demonstrates suitability for the intended application. Consider the competence and information needed to operate the designed service.

Evidence and judgement

A proportionate plan identifies decision points, outputs, authority and evidence. Iterative work is compatible with control when changing inputs and decisions remain intelligible. Examine the design interface with production or service delivery before approving the plan.

Avoid this mistake

Outsourcing design does not automatically make it inapplicable. Nor does ISO 9001 prescribe a fixed waterfall lifecycle or a separate document for each review stage.

Guidance referral

A.8.3 clarifies the design purpose. APG design guidance offers supplementary audit questions for the earlier edition. [3]

8.3.3 and 8.3.4 Inputs review verification and validation

Required outcome

Under 8.3.3, determine essential design inputs, considering function and performance, experience from similar work, applicable legal requirements, adopted standards or codes, and consequences of failure. Resolve ambiguity and conflicting inputs and keep evidence. Under 8.3.4, define intended results, review whether the design can meet requirements, verify output against inputs, validate suitability for intended application or use, address identified problems and keep evidence of the activities. [1]

Practical translation

Review asks whether the design direction remains adequate. Verification asks whether defined outputs satisfy their inputs. Validation asks whether the resulting product or service suits the intended use. Activities can be combined where appropriate, but the questions should not be confused.

Application in the work

For a fixture, checking drawing dimensions can contribute to verification. Testing the fixture under representative service conditions can contribute to validation. Neither label is sufficient without an appropriate method and acceptance criteria. For a service, a realistic pilot can examine whether the designed process answers the customer’s intended need.

Evidence and judgement

Maintain traceability from a significant input to the corresponding design evidence and the action taken where a problem is found. Inputs may develop iteratively, but later changes need evaluation. Record the scope and limitations of a test rather than claiming that a narrow demonstration validates every possible use.

Avoid this mistake

A customer signature is not a universal substitute for verification or validation. Holding a meeting called Design Review does not show that the required technical questions were answered.

Guidance referral

A.8.3 distinguishes the purposes of the controls. ISO 10007 supports the associated configuration discipline. [5]

8.3.5 and 8.3.6 Outputs and design changes

Required outcome

Under 8.3.5, ensure design outputs meet inputs, suit subsequent delivery processes, include or identify relevant monitoring, measurement and acceptance criteria, and specify the characteristics and information essential to intended purpose and proper provision. Keep evidence of outputs. Under 8.3.6, identify, review and control changes during or after design so conformity is not adversely affected. Keep evidence of the change, review, authorisation and necessary preventive actions. [1]

Practical translation

A design output is ready when the next process can use it correctly. That may require more than a drawing: a test method, software configuration, service instruction, critical characteristic or acceptance condition can be essential.

Application in the work

A material substitution changes a fixture after an initial design review. Examine strength, dimensional behaviour, inspection requirements and the evidence affected by the change. Decide what needs rechecking and communicate the authorised configuration to procurement and production. Do not assume that a similar trade description establishes equivalence.

Evidence and judgement

Select a changed output and reconstruct the current approved configuration. Compare the change assessment, authority, affected tests and information available at delivery. Review whether already supplied items or existing users are affected.

Avoid this mistake

A new revision number is an identifier, not a technical assessment. Design change control is related to, but not interchangeable with, an operational change review under 8.5.6 or a system change under 6.3.

Guidance referral

A.8.3 and ISO 10007:2017 support understanding of configuration and changes. [5]

8.4.1 and 8.4.2 Provider selection and proportionate controls

Required outcome

Under 8.4.1, control external processes and outputs used in the organisation’s supply, supplied directly on its behalf, or performed as part of an outsourced process. Set and apply criteria for provider evaluation, selection, performance monitoring and reevaluation, with evidence and resulting actions. Under 8.4.2, preserve control of outsourced processes, define provider and output controls, consider the consequence of failure and the provider’s own controls, and establish necessary verification. [1]

Practical translation

The organisation remains accountable for its customer output. A supplier certificate can inform evaluation but does not establish that a particular technical result or delivery meets the agreed requirement. Control should reflect the actual dependency and consequence.

Application in the work

Buying office stationery and buying a specialised heat treatment need different evaluation and output assurance. For the latter, establish the relevant capability, method, traceability and acceptance evidence. Decide what independent checks or provider oversight are necessary in the circumstances.

Evidence and judgement

Trace a critical outsourced step to the selection rationale, current performance, specification and accepted output. Check how an adverse trend changes control or triggers reevaluation. An approved list is useful only if its status is supported by the evaluation and monitoring it represents.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not automatically require every supplier to hold ISO certification or to undergo an annual site audit. Nor does outsourcing an activity remove it from the organisation’s QMS controls.

Guidance referral

A.8.4 clarifies retained accountability. APG external provider guidance is a supporting audit referral. [3]

8.4.3 Tell the provider what correct provision requires

Required outcome

Check the adequacy of requirements before communicating them to external providers. As appropriate, specify the required process or output; approvals of output, method, process, equipment and release; competence or qualifications; interfaces with the organisation and relevant parties; performance controls; and planned verification or validation at the relevant location. [1]

Practical translation

A purchase order must convey what the provider needs to know to deliver correctly. A generic request for compliance can leave the significant acceptance question unanswered. The specification and the output control should tell a coherent story.

Application in the work

An engineering order requires a particular test method and report content. State the effective method revision, required technical authority, sample identity, acceptance information and any intended customer witness or verification arrangement. Confirm that the provider understands the requirement and can meet it before the work is committed.

Evidence and judgement

Compare a provider’s actual result with what was communicated. Review changes, ambiguities and assumptions at the interface. If a particular qualification or approval is required, establish the source of that requirement and communicate it accurately.

Avoid this mistake

A provider cannot reliably meet a critical requirement that was never made clear. Conversely, imposing blanket qualifications without an applicable need can create cost without improving control.

Guidance referral

A.8.4 gives explanatory context. ISO 10005 can help connect contract level requirements with the provider control in a quality plan. [4]

8.5.1 Controlled production and service conditions

Required outcome

Provide controlled conditions as applicable: usable information about the output, work and intended result; suitable monitoring and measuring resources; checks at suitable stages against process and acceptance criteria; suitable infrastructure and environment; competent people including required qualifications; validation and periodic revalidation of processes whose resulting output cannot be verified later; actions to prevent human error; and controlled release, delivery and subsequent activities. [1]

Practical translation

Controlled conditions are the arrangements that make correct work a repeatable result. They include the way a person interacts with the method and the response to an unavailable control. End inspection cannot always recover evidence that was never produced during a consequential process.

Application in the work

For an operation whose result cannot be fully verified afterwards, establish suitable evidence of process capability and revalidation. For a service, a decision may depend on information only available during delivery. Plan the competent observation, record and acceptance condition while that evidence can still be obtained.

Evidence and judgement

Observe the actual task and compare it with the approved conditions. Assess relevant human error opportunities such as look alike parts, unclear revisions or an automated default. Error prevention can include better design and checks rather than relying only on reminders to be careful.

Avoid this mistake

A signed traveller does not demonstrate every controlled condition. Validation is not an excuse to omit available output checks, and a generic process validation statement cannot establish the capability of every operating condition.

Guidance referral

A.8.5 clarifies controlled conditions and process validation. The supporting measurement and competence requirements in Clause 7 remain connected to operational control.

8.5.2 and 8.5.3 Identity status and entrusted property

Required outcome

Under 8.5.2, identify outputs where needed for conformity and identify their monitoring and measurement status throughout delivery. Where traceability is required, control unique identity and keep the information needed to reconstruct it. Under 8.5.3, identify, verify, protect and safeguard customer or provider property under organisational control or use. Report lost, damaged or unsuitable property to its owner and keep evidence of what occurred. [1]

Practical translation

Identification tells you what something is. Status tells you what checks or decisions apply. Traceability links the output to the required history. Property can include samples, tools, premises, information and personal data, not just physical goods.

Application in the work

A sample label identifies the item but does not show which method revision, preparation and review produced its result. Link the required history without confusing a QR code with the evidence itself. If entrusted information is corrupted or a tool is damaged, initiate the appropriate reporting and control arrangements.

Evidence and judgement

Choose an output and reconstruct its required history and status. Review an entrusted item or dataset, its condition on receipt, protection and any incident report. Apply the actual required traceability depth rather than assuming serialisation is universal.

Avoid this mistake

A unique reference is not a universal requirement for every output. Conversely, a label alone does not fulfil a traceability requirement that includes process history and decision evidence.

Guidance referral

A.8.5 clarifies identity, traceability and property. Information security or privacy obligations may impose controls beyond this quality requirement.

8.5.4 to 8.5.6 Preserve conformity and control later changes

Required outcome

Under 8.5.4, preserve outputs as needed to maintain conformity during production and provision. Under 8.5.5, fulfil required activities after delivery, considering applicable legal obligations, unwanted consequences, nature, use and intended lifetime, customer requirements and feedback. Under 8.5.6, review and control changes to continuing production or provision and keep evidence of the review, authorising people and necessary actions. [1]

Practical translation

Conformity can be lost after technically correct work. Contamination, transit damage, incompatible file conversion or an uncontrolled service change can invalidate what the customer receives. Later support responsibilities should be determined rather than assumed to end at dispatch.

Application in the work

A report is correctly reviewed but converted to a format that drops essential information. Treat the transmission and presentation as part of preservation. A production route then changes to use a substitute process. Review the effect on the approved criteria, resources and previous validation before treating the change as equivalent.

Evidence and judgement

Follow an output through storage, transfer, delivery and a relevant support obligation. For a changed operation, examine the review, authorisation and resulting action. Separate product design changes, operational changes and QMS changes where their assessment purposes differ, while keeping their records linked.

Avoid this mistake

ISO 9001 does not prescribe a universal warranty or retention period. A routine change is not necessarily harmless simply because the output drawing has not changed.

Guidance referral

A.8.5 explains preservation and later activities. ISO 10007 supports configuration awareness across the relevant lifecycle. [5]

8.6 Release supported by the actual acceptance evidence

Required outcome

Implement planned verification at appropriate stages to establish that product or service requirements have been fulfilled. Do not release to the customer until those arrangements are satisfactorily completed, unless a relevant authority and, where applicable, the customer approve an exception. Keep evidence of conformity to the acceptance criteria and traceability to the people authorising release. [1]

Practical translation

Release is an evidence supported decision. A signature is meaningful when it identifies an authorised person and connects that decision to the applicable criteria and results for the actual output. Earlier stage approvals may support progression without establishing final customer release.

Application in the work

Before releasing an assembly, reconcile the agreed revision, provider evidence, inspection results, open exceptions and the release authority. For a service, check the agreed content and required review. Make any permitted exceptional approval explicit and bounded rather than implying that an incomplete check was performed.

Evidence and judgement

Choose one released output and reconstruct the decision. Determine what the release record proves, who had authority and how any exception was approved. Technical and applicable legal conditions need their own competent assessment; an ISO release exception is not a general permission to disregard them.

Avoid this mistake

A customer’s urgency is not release evidence. A pass against obsolete acceptance criteria does not establish conformity to the current agreed requirement.

Guidance referral

A.8.6 explains staged confirmation. Refer to 8.2 for the agreed requirement, 8.7 for output nonconformity and 10.2 for corrective action.

8.7 Control the nonconforming output and its decision history

Required outcome

Under 8.7.1, identify and control nonconforming outputs against unintended use or supply, including problems detected during provision or after delivery. Respond according to their nature and effect, using appropriate correction, containment, segregation, return or suspension, customer information or authorised concession. Recheck conformity after correction. Under 8.7.2, preserve evidence of the problem, action, any concession and the authority deciding the response. [1]

Practical translation

First establish the affected output and prevent an unsupported further decision. A correction makes the particular output acceptable. A concession is a specific authorised acceptance decision, not a statement that the original requirement was met. Investigating a systemic cause belongs in the connected corrective action process.

Application in the work

A provider result is found to use the wrong revision after an assembly has been delivered. Identify the potentially affected population, assess the technical consequence, control further use and determine appropriate customer communication and recovery. Record what is known, what remains uncertain and who can authorise the disposition.

Evidence and judgement

Test whether records distinguish problem description, containment, correction, concession and subsequent verification. Follow the final disposition through inventory or service records so the system state matches the authorised decision. Consider similar outputs when the evidence suggests a wider issue.

Avoid this mistake

Marking an item as rejected does not prevent use if the status is not communicated or enforced. Closing a nonconforming output is not automatically evidence that its cause has been eliminated.

Guidance referral

A.8.7 explains the breadth of nonconforming outputs. APG nonconformity guidance supports audit technique without adding mandatory investigation forms. [3]

Apply the clause across the team

These responsibilities are recommended applications for the reader groups. The organisation still determines its own roles, competence and authority.

Reader	Contribution	Useful output
IMS manager	Maintain the links between requirements, controls, exceptions and release.	A reconstructable delivery and assurance trail.
Engineer	Define capability, methods, acceptance evidence and consequences of change.	A competent technical basis for review and disposition.
Leadership team	Align commitments, resources and exception authority.	A defensible supply decision and action on systemic constraints.

Use it in an integrated management system

Operational delivery can depend on controls owned by several disciplines. A change of material may affect quality, safety, environmental handling and data requirements. One integrated change record can coordinate these reviews, but each applicable condition needs an appropriate assessment and authority. Neither a QMS approval nor customer acceptance alone establishes fulfilment of every other obligation.

Connections that should remain visible

Related clause	Connection to this decision
Clauses 4 and 5	Scope, requirements and leadership authority frame the promise.
Clauses 6 and 7	Planning and capability make the operating route supportable.
Clause 9	Delivery evidence feeds conformity and provider evaluation.
Clause 10	Output control connects to assessment of causes and systemic improvement.

Engineering case Four passed inspections against an old criterion

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Kingsford Manufacturing reviews 20 completed orders. Four used a superseded acceptance criterion, and all four were recorded as passing it. This invented sample identifies a requirement transfer failure in 20 per cent of the selected orders. It does not establish a 20 per cent product defect rate.

The team identifies the affected revisions and potentially wider population. Engineering assesses actual conformity against the relevant requirement. Management controls further release while the evidence is evaluated and establishes the necessary customer, provider and internal actions. The immediate question concerns outputs; the systemic question concerns why the changed requirement did not reach the control.

Trace the chain from customer change through contract review, design where applicable, provider information, operational instructions, measurement and release. Check each handover rather than assuming final inspection can compensate for incorrect input. Record any authorised disposition distinctly from the correction of the document.

A later review should examine criterion consistency in representative new work and check for unintended delay. A clean sample supports a bounded conclusion about the sampled work; it does not prove that recurrence is impossible.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Service case A redesigned inspection service

Fictional scenario for practical discussion

Fictional Bracken Technical Services develops a new reporting service in response to a customer’s need for clearer prioritisation. A trial report looks attractive, but the team has not agreed what the customer will use its categories to decide or how ambiguous evidence will be handled.

The design inputs need intended use, required characteristics and relevant limits. Plan review, verification and validation as distinct questions. Verify that the report reflects the input evidence correctly. Validate that the service can meet the agreed intended use under representative conditions. Resolve problems before presenting the trial as an established capability.

Before operational release, establish competent reviewers, current instructions, record integrity, customer communication and acceptance criteria. If parts are outsourced, communicate the required methods and output evidence. Preserve the controlled report during conversion and transmission.

The service design may evolve iteratively. Retain the rationale, configuration, authority and evidence through those iterations. A favourable customer reaction is useful information, but it does not by itself establish every technical or contractual condition.

Use the case with your team

Identify the applicable requirement, distinguish the observed facts from assumptions and decide what evidence would support the next action. Explain who has the authority and competence to make that decision. Discuss what would contradict your initial conclusion.

Your decision and the evidence still needed

Audit the decision and plan the response

The following prompts are practical aids. Define the audit criteria and scope using the applicable requirements and the organisation’s own arrangements. A prompt in this table is not a separate mandatory ISO requirement.

Subject	Question to test	Weak signal
Requirement	Does the accepted promise match the current controlling criterion?	Sales, provider and inspection use different revisions.
Design	Are review, verification and validation questions actually answered?	A single signature substitutes for all three purposes.
External provision	What establishes that this provider and output are suitable?	Certificate or approved list treated as complete assurance.
Release and exception	Can the authorising decision be reconstructed?	A pass result or urgent request used without applicable criteria.

A focused implementation discussion

1. Select a delivered order including a change or exception.

2. Trace the requirement through design, external provision and operational controls as applicable.

3. Reconstruct the release evidence and any authorised disposition.

4. Agree one weak handover to improve and a representative effectiveness check.

Write a useful finding

Separate the criterion, what was observed and the resulting gap. Keep an improvement suggestion distinct from a nonconformity. Where immediate control is needed, use the appropriate operational authority rather than waiting for the audit report.

Record the next decision

Identify the responsible owner, the action or decision needed, the evidence of implementation and the test of effectiveness where relevant. Set timing proportionate to the issue. The organisation must determine what can proceed while uncertainty remains.

Requirement to release trace

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Customer promise and effective specification

2. Review capability and resolved differences

3. Design or provider controls as applicable

4. Operating criteria resources and verification

5. Change exception or nonconforming output decision

6. Release evidence authority and delivery record

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

Change or concession decision

Reusable RPG worksheet for internal application

Complete for one defined process or decision. Reference supporting records rather than copying a whole report. The worksheet is a suggested method; its fields are not additional requirements.

1. Affected output population and current status

2. Original requirement proposed change or deviation

3. Competent assessment and consequences

4. Required authority and customer involvement where applicable

5. Disposition correction and conformity verification

6. Retained decision history and linked corrective action

Completion check: can another competent reviewer understand the basis, authority and limitations of the decision?

References and publication information

Official publication records and public guidance checked on 8 November 2026. The referral notes identify scope and appropriate use; they are not full reviews of the supporting standards. Obtain the full publication where it is needed.

[1] ISO 9001:2026 Quality management systems Requirements
Primary clause basis: the supplied standard text and its informative Annex A. Open official record

[2] ISO/TS 9002:2016 Guidelines for the application of ISO 9001:2015
Earlier edition implementation guidance; check compatibility with 2026. Open official record

[3] ISO 9001 Auditing Practices Group
Supplementary audit papers, many for the 2015 edition. Open official record

[4] ISO 10005:2018 Guidelines for quality plans
Guidance referral for a specific output, project or contract. Open official record

[5] ISO 10007:2017 Guidelines for configuration management
Guidance referral for controlled product and service configuration. Open official record

[6] ISO 10002:2018 Guidelines for complaints handling
Guidance referral for the complaints handling process. Open official record

[7] ISO 9000:2026 Quality management Fundamentals and vocabulary
Normative vocabulary referral identified by ISO 9001. Open official record

[8] ISO 9000 Glossary Guidance on selected words 2025
Supporting language clarification. Use formal definitions where applicable. Open official record

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Protect the requirement through to release

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
Agree

Understand the intended output and acceptance requirement.

02
Review

Establish capability before committing to supply.

03
Design

Connect inputs, controlled outputs and intended use.

04
Provide

Control external and internal delivery conditions.

05
Verify

Check the actual output against the right criterion.

06
Release

Retain the evidence and the authorising decision.

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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Keep the exception visible

Practical prompts for applying the requirements. Read with the publication and the licensed standard.

01
Identify

Which outputs and customers could be affected?

02
Control

Prevent unsupported use or further delivery.

03
Assess

Determine the consequence through competent review.

04
Authorise

Make any correction or concession decision explicit.

05
Verify

Recheck conformity after correction.

06
Learn

Evaluate the need for corrective action under 10.2.

RPG recommended practice. These prompts do not add ISO requirements.

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